Guitar Exercises - Section XII, Level 88

Rock, Hard-Rock, and Metal Groove Control

Eighth-Note Drive • Gallops • Pedal Tones • Power-Chord Displacement • Accent Architecture

Level 88 of 105. HARD STOP after Level 105.

The goal is not maximum distortion or speed. The goal is a riff whose pulse, mute depth, accents, rests, and chord punctuation remain stable enough to sound intentional at any gain level.

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I	Thirty-two-bar riff-performance capstone	256
J	Recovery and groove audit	64
	TOTAL	1536

Core rule: riff identity must survive on a clean tone and at reduced tempo.

Reference - Attack and Mute Vocabulary

Symbol	Meaning	Execution
O	open/full power-chord attack	allow controlled sustain
M	palm-muted pitched attack	bridge-hand mute; pitch remains clear
x	dead/muted contact	no stable pitch
-	rest/air stroke	no contact
>	accent	more attack, not necessarily more duration
~	sustain	no new attack

Practice every rhythm first on one low E note. Add power chords only after the attack pattern is stable.

Module A - Eighth-Note Drive and Mute Depth

Pass	Grid	Mute target
1	M M M M M M M M	heavy mute; short low-E pitch
2	M M M M M M M M	medium mute; more fundamental
3	M M M M M M M M	light mute; near-open
4	O O O O O O O O	fully open reference
5	M M M M O O O O	verse-to-chorus lift
6	M O M O M O M O	alternating mute/open
7	>M M >M M >M M >M M	accents every two eighths
8	>M M M >M M M >M M	3+3+2 accent feel

Use E5, A5, D5, and G5. The mute changes timbre and duration, not tempo.

Module B - Gallops and Reverse Gallops

Count each beat as 1 e & a. Gallop = long-short-short; reverse gallop = short-short-long.

Cell	Sixteenth grid	Picking goal
1	M - M M	D - D U
2	M M - M	D U - U
3	M M M -	D U D -
4	- M M M	- U D U
5	M - M M | M - M M	repeat without reset
6	M M - M | M M - M	reverse-gallop continuity
7	M - M M | M M - M	alternate gallop/reverse
8	>M - M M | M - >M M	accent displacement

Begin on one string. Then move the final attack of each beat to a power chord while the pedal note remains muted.

Module C - Pedal-Tone Riffs

Riff	Pedal	Chord punctuation	Pattern
1	E pedal	G5-A5	E E G5 E | E E A5 E
2	E pedal	D5-C5	E E E D5 | E C5 E E
3	A pedal	C5-D5	A A C5 A | A A D5 A
4	D pedal	F5-G5	D D F5 D | D G5 D D
5	E pedal	F5-G5-A5	E F5 E G5 | E A5 G5 E
6	E pedal	D5-A5	gallop pedal + chord on beat 4

Mute the pedal more heavily than the chord punctuation. The chord should sound like a structural event, not merely a louder version of the pedal.

Module D - Power-Chord Displacement

Cell	Chord attacks	Purpose
1	1, 2, 3, 4	downbeat reference
2	&, &, &, &	offbeat power chords
3	1, &2, 3, &4	alternating placement
4	&1, 2, &3, 4	reverse displacement
5	1, a2, &3, 4	late-sixteenth tension
6	a1, 2, a3, 4	pickup-driven riff
7	1, &2, a3, &4	syncopated hard-rock cell
8	&1, a2, &3, a4	high-displacement test

Use E5-G5-A5-D5. Keep a muted low-E sixteenth grid underneath the chord attacks.

Module E - Accent Architecture

Accent cycle	16 eighth-note attacks	Effect
2	1 0 1 0 1 0 1 0 ...	square drive
3	1 0 0 1 0 0 1 0 ...	cross-bar 3 grouping
4	1 0 0 0 ...	quarter-note landmarks
5	1 0 0 0 0 1 ...	longer cross-bar cycle
3+3+2	1 0 0 1 0 0 1 0	asymmetrical bar identity
2+2+4	1 0 1 0 1 0 0 0	front-loaded bar

Accent cycles are first played on one pitch, then mapped to chord changes. Do not move the barline to follow the accent.

Module F - Open/Muted Contrast and Section Lift

Section	Pedal behavior	Chord behavior	Dynamic
Verse	heavy palm mute	short punctuation	mp
Pre-chorus	medium mute	more frequent power chords	mf
Chorus	light/open	longer chord sustain	f
Breakdown	heavy mute + rests	low-register hits	f but sparse
Bridge	mixed mute	syncopated chords	mf
Outro	open then progressively muted	final sustained tonic	f -> p

Use the same E5-G5-A5-D5 harmony through all six textures. Section identity must come from orchestration, not new chords.

Module G - Riff Construction and Variation

Riff	Cell	Identity
Riff A	E E G5 E | E A5 G5 E	pedal + punctuation
Riff B	E - E E | G5 E A5 E	gallop
Riff C	E E E D5 | E C5 D5 E	descending chord answer
Riff D	E G5 E A5 | E - D5 E	displaced power chords
Riff E	E E G5 A5 | E E D5 E	two-chord climax
Riff F	E F5 E G5 | A5 G5 E -	chromatic/diatonic color
Riff G	E E E E | G5 - A5 -	density contrast
Riff H	E - G5 - | A5 E D5 E	space-heavy riff

For each riff create exactly three variations: change accent only; change final chord only; change note density only. Preserve the original rhythmic identity.

Module H - Study 1 - Rock eighth-note drive

| E5 | G5 | A5 | E5 | E5 | D5 | A5 | E5 |

steady eighths; medium mute; open chorus hits

Pass	Requirement
1	one muted root only
2	add accents
3	add power chords
4	add mute-depth changes
5	add section dynamics
6	record clean tone, then gain tone

Module H - Study 2 - Hard-rock pedal riff

| E5 | G5 A5 | E5 | D5 | E5 | G5 | A5 D5 | E5 |

low-E pedal plus chord punctuation

Pass	Requirement
1	one muted root only
2	add accents
3	add power chords
4	add mute-depth changes
5	add section dynamics
6	record clean tone, then gain tone

Module H - Study 3 - Gallop study

| E5 | E5 | G5 | A5 | E5 | D5 | A5 | E5 |

gallop verse; reverse-gallop response

Pass	Requirement
1	one muted root only
2	add accents
3	add power chords
4	add mute-depth changes
5	add section dynamics
6	record clean tone, then gain tone

Module H - Study 4 - Breakdown/chorus contrast

| E5 | D5 | C5 | B5 | E5 | G5 | A5 | E5 |

bars 1-4 sparse breakdown; 5-8 open chorus

Pass	Requirement
1	one muted root only
2	add accents
3	add power chords
4	add mute-depth changes
5	add section dynamics
6	record clean tone, then gain tone

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Riff-Performance Capstone

Bars	Harmony	Riff role	Texture	Dynamic
1-4	E5-G5-A5-E5	rock drive	medium mute	mf
5-8	E pedal + G5/A5	hard rock	pedal punctuation	mf
9-12	E5-G5-A5-D5	gallop	heavy mute	f
13-16	E5-D5-C5-B5	breakdown	rests + low hits	f
17-20	E5-G5-A5-E5	open chorus	light/open	f
21-24	E pedal + D5/C5	reverse gallop	heavy/medium	mf
25-28	E5-G5-A5-D5	syncopated riff	displaced chords	f
29-32	E5-D5-A5-E5	outro	open -> mute -> sustain	f -> p

One master tempo. No neutral bar between sections. The last bar of each section must prepare the next mute depth, register, and rhythmic behavior.

Module J - Recovery and Groove Audit

Failure	Immediate repair
Palm mute kills pitch	move hand slightly away from bridge; reduce pressure
Gallop rushes	one beat at a time; foot marks quarter notes
Pedal/chord balance unclear	mute pedal harder; open chord punctuation
Power-chord shift late	end pedal one sixteenth early, then restore full cell
Accent changes tempo	play all notes equal, then re-add accent
Breakdown becomes slower	keep silent subdivision with picking hand/foot
Gain hides articulation	return to clean tone and reduce note density
Form lost	quarter-note E pedal until next 4-bar boundary

Mastery: 14/16 or better on two separate days across pulse, mute depth, gallop control, pedal/chord balance, displacement, accent architecture, section contrast, and recovery. No zero in pulse, gallop control, pedal/chord balance, or recovery.

Next: Level 89 develops country, Americana, and hybrid-picking groove principles - alternating bass, boom-chuck, train rhythm, double-stops, chicken-picking accents, and bass/chord independence.